

PHIL 2530 / RELST 2630
Religion and Reason
Fall 2026
Course Syllabus

What must (or could) God be like, and what reasons do we have for thinking that a being of that sort actually exists? What difference would (or could) the existence of God make to our lives? Religion & Reason examines the idea, shared by several major world religions, that God must be an absolutely perfect being. What attributes must a perfect being have: must it have a mind, be a person, care for human beings? Is the concept of a perfect being coherent? Is the existence of a perfect being compatible with the presence of evil in the world, the existence of human freedom, the nature of the world as modern science understands it? Does what is morally right and wrong depend in any important way on the nature or will of a perfect being? Is a perfect being among the things that actually inhabit our universe? The course approaches these questions with the tools and methods of philosophical reason and through readings drawn from both classic texts and contemporary philosophical discussion.

Instructor: Prof. Cole Mitchell

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Office: Goldwin Smith G67

Office hours: Friday 10AM – 11AM and by appointment

Class time: Tuesdays/Thursdays 2:55 to 4:10PM

Classroom: Goldwin Smith GW09

Course website: Canvas

Required work: A total of 100 points is possible:

- (1) One short paper (4–6 pages/15 points)
Due Thursday, October 8th
- (2) Three exams: an early exam (10 points), a small midterm (10 points) and a final (20 points):
- (3) Discussion participation and reading questions (10 points)
- (4) Attendance and in-class work (30 points)
- (5) Logic module on Canvas (5 points)

Texts: The readings will also be available online on the course website.

Reference text: The most important of these is the online *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (plato.stanford.edu).

Email policy: I will check email at least twice a week. If I haven't yet responded to your email, you are strongly encouraged to send follow-up emails—I will not be offended!

Main Readings and Topics:

Week 1: Hume's *Dialogues concerning Natural Religion (DNR)*, Part I; skepticism, proofs and knowledge in religion

Week 2: Pascal's Wager, Clifford & James on the ethics of belief

Week 3: Plantinga on proper function, different philosophical conceptions of God

Week 4: divine simplicity, univocity and analogy

Week 5: occasionalism and deism, Ibn Sina on essence and existence

Week 6: Anselm's ontological argument, Aquinas's Five Ways

Week 7: Clarke's cosmological argument and Hume's *DNR* Part IX, *kalam* and the Big Bang

Week 8: Paley's analogical design argument

Week 9: Hume's *DNR* Parts II to VIII, XII (excerpt); cosmic fine-tuning

Week 10: moral argument, Euthyphro dilemma

Week 11: problem of evil: logical vs. evidential; theodicies vs. skeptical theism

Week 12: Bayle on Manicheanism, Hume's *DNR* X to XI

Week 13: Hume on miracles

Week 14/15: class-chosen topic: divine foreknowledge and free will, afterlife, divine hiddenness, ...?

NOTE: The information contained in the course syllabus, other than the grade and absence policies, may be subject to change with reasonable advance notice, as deemed appropriate by the instructor.